The Role of Trust When Adolescents Search for and Appraise Online Health Information

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Objective To assess the role of trust when adolescents search for and appraise online health information.

Study design A systematic search of online databases (MEDLINE, EMBASE, PsycINFO, and ERIC) was performed. Google Scholar and reference lists for included studies were manually searched for additional articles. Studies were included if they examined the role of trust when adolescents (in the 13- to 18-year-old age range) searched for and/or appraised online health information. Findings were synthesized using thematic analysis.

Results There were 22 studies that met the inclusion criteria. Four key themes were identified: adolescents generally distrust the Internet but use it anyway (subthemes were why adolescents distrust online health information; why adolescents still use online health information), adolescents use heuristics to appraise the trustworthiness of online health information (subthemes were different heuristics used by different adolescents, range of heuristics used by adolescents), adolescents trust websites more than social media or social networking sites, and adolescents' level of trust in online health information guides their actions and responses.

Conclusions Adolescents often distrust health information from the Internet, but continue to use it. Adolescents are aware of the need to evaluate the trustworthiness of online health information; however, their approaches vary in sophistication. As the reach and content of the Internet expands, it is important to equip adolescents with effective eHealth literacy to assess the trustworthiness of online health information. *(J Pediatr 2020;221:215-23)*.

The Internet is a convenient and interactive tool for consumers to search for current, relevant, and personalized information.[1,2] More than 80% of Internet users search for health information online, making it one of the most popular online activities.[3] However, not all online health information is reliable and many Internet users access online health information without regularly assessing its quality.[4,5] To effectively navigate this interconnected space and retrieve reliable health information, users must be able to evaluate the relevance and quality of online information when deciding what sources to read, how to read them, and how to use online information to problem solve.[6]

The Internet is commonly used by adolescents to search for information on potentially sensitive or stigmatizing topics, including sexual health and sexuality.[7-11] Adolescents may be particularly vulnerable to misinformation online owing to their maturing cognitive development and more limited life experience.[12,13] Adolescent Internet users risk exposure to information that can have harmful consequences for well-being, including proanorexia websites, or information on self-injurious behaviors and suicide.[14-16] Adolescents are increasingly using social media for health information; yet, social media can rapidly spread poor quality or biased information and potentially facilitate sexual exploitation.[17-21]

Health-related behaviors and literacy acquired during adolescence are carried through to adulthood.[8,15,22] To search within the networked world of online health information, adolescents require skills related to eHealth literacy.[23] Evidence indicates that adolescents' eHealth literacy may not be as advanced as the "digital native" discourse might suggest.[24,25] However, the acquisition of such skills is important; adolescents who are more skeptical of the trustworthiness of the Internet can more accurately retrieve health information.[8]

To better equip educators, parents, and health professionals to provide adolescents with appropriate online health information and enhance adolescents' eHealth literacy, there is a need to examine how adolescents determine the trustworthiness of online health information. Our previous systematic review explored how adolescents search for and appraise online health information and indicated that trust significantly impacts adolescents' online health information-seeking behaviors.[26] The current systematic review aimed to extend these findings by assessing the role of trust when adolescents search for and appraise online health information.

COREQ	Criteria for reporting qualitative research
SNS	Social networking site

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The authors declare no conflicts of interest.

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https://doi.org/10.1016/j.jpeds.2020.02.074